

Michigan Technology Exploration Award

About the MI TEA

The Michigan Technology Exploration Award (MI TEA) honors high school students who actively arrange meetings with and learn from technology professionals. The pathway to earning this award gives recipients a comprehensive understanding of various technology careers and helps them build their professional networks early. It enhances professional skills and introduces students to experiences not typically included in most schools' curricula.

Hosted by the [Lansing ACM-W Chapter](#), MI TEA is modeled after and offered in collaboration with the [Minnesota Aspirations in Computing Technology Exploration Award](#) and the [NCWIT Aspirations in Computing Awards](#).

Timeline

Nov 24, 2025	Info session (webinar) Recorded – join live for Q&A
Nov 25, 2025	Submissions open Students begin submitting their reflections
Mar 15, 2026	Submissions close All reflections due by 11:50 pm EST.
Mar 30, 2026	Winners announced Students receive notifications
Apr 18, 2026	MI AiC Awards Ceremony Students recognized in public ceremony.

Application Rules

To receive an MI TEA, you must complete the following steps with at least 5 technology practitioners between November 25, 2025, and March 15, 2026.

- Request an interview
 - Directly request an interview with a technology practitioner (see suggestions in the TEA Resources)
 - Send the practitioner a link to the MI TEA Practitioner Letter

- An eligible practitioner cannot be a family member
- A maximum of two practitioners may work for the same company.
- Conduct the interview
 - Ask the practitioner about their job, about their career path, if they have any career or life advice to share, and at least one other question of interest to you (see suggestions in the TEA Resources).
 - The interview should take 45-60 minutes.
- Follow up with the practitioner
 - Send a thank-you email that highlights a benefit you gained from the interview.
 - Email the practitioner a link to the MI TEA Award announcement when it is released in March, along with information about the award ceremony.
- Submit your reflection
 - Write a reflection on what you learned that includes:
 - Details about the practitioner's role, including an overview of the organization they work for and their contributions to the organization's mission. (Minimum of 250 words)
 - A description of the practitioner's career path (e.g., education, prior experience, inspiration, etc.). (Minimum of 150 words)
 - Career or life advice offered by the practitioner, including what you learned from any additional questions you asked. (Minimum of 100 words)
 - A statement to document any use of generative AI for minor editing support, such as checking grammar, clarity, or organization. ***Do not use AI to generate ideas, content, or descriptions of the interview itself.*** Your reflection must be based solely on your conversation with the technology professional and should accurately reflect what you learned from that interview.
 - Paste your reflection into the electronic form here.
 - Check the box confirming that the reflection is your own work and press the Submit button.

The MI TEA application reviewers may contact the technology practitioners you interviewed to verify that the award requirements were met. Failure to complete the tasks as described above may result in disqualification of the interview.

Resources to Aid Your Interviews

Visit the Technology Exploration Award Resources page for helpful interview tips and guidance on finding technology practitioners and conducting outreach.

(include a View Resources button)

Rewards

Each award recipient will be publicly recognized on April 18 at the 2026 MI Aspirations in Computing Awards ceremony, where they will receive a MI TEA Award certificate and medal. They will also be eligible for prizes donated by sponsors of the MI AiC and MI TEA programs. Check back in March for details about the prizes. A MI TEA Award certificate and medal will be mailed to recipients who cannot attend the ceremony in April.

FAQ

Who is eligible to apply for an MI TEA?

Students in grades 9-12 who live in Michigan and are registered members of the [Aspirations in Computing \(AiC\) Community](#).

Who qualifies as a technology professional for the purpose of an MI TEA?

Someone who provides technology skills and services either part-time or full-time and has at least 2 years of experience in a technology-related role.

Can I use AI when writing my reflections?

Students may use generative AI tools only for minor editing support—such as checking grammar, clarity, or organization—but not for generating ideas, content, or descriptions of the interview itself. All responses in the application must be based solely on the student's own conversation with the technology professional and must accurately reflect what they learned from that interview. Using AI to create, fabricate, or significantly rewrite the student's takeaways, summaries, or insights is not allowed.

